

succeeded in erasing the debt, unfortunately they couldn't succeed in erasing Susie's memory of it. Susie and Sam understood clearly why debt is the primary issue that couples quarrel about.

Each partner brings his or her financial past and present into the marriage. Even though one partner is not responsible for debts incurred prior to marriage by the other, their legacy will impact the couple as a whole. Susie understood why her husband had gotten in debt, but she also understood that even though the debt he had acquired before their marriage was not legally her problem, the reality of his debt load was their problem!

It probably is a good idea to find out your spouse-to-be's credit history before you say, "I do." I suggest a frank pre-marriage discussion about each of your respective financial situations so that no surprises spoil your marital bliss.

So as to never repeat their debt burden again, Susie and Sam have two credit cards now and both are in *Susie's* wallet!

Out of Sight, Out of Mind

Some partners purposely hide purchases or assets from the other. In fact, a 2005 *Redbook*/lawyers.com survey found that nearly one-third of adults who are in a committed relationship say they have been dishonest with their partner about their spending habits. Despite their lack of candor on this issue, 24 percent of those polled said that honesty about finances was more important than honesty about fidelity.

When the data is separated by gender, women are more likely to be the ones with less candor (33 percent for women and 26 percent for men). In fact, one in four women said they lied to their partner about the money they spent on items like clothing or shoes. Many women may feel they can safely "bend" the truth since they have had success in hiding the purchases through their husbands' inattention to their wardrobe details.

Additionally, the poll found that 18 percent of adults admitted to having entirely separate bank accounts. Without

